duolingo-brand-foundation.md

#duolingo #brandfoundation

Duolingo - Where can we fly?

Brand Foundation: Strategy & Research

- ✅ Brand selection
- ✅ Competitive landscape
- ✅ Consumer segmentation



AI in Marketing, Assignment 1 · Cindy Ha

PART 1A

Duolingo: gamified learning, now far beyond language

What it is: a mobile app teaching **40+** languages, plus Math, Music, and Chess through short, game-like daily lessons.

Why I picked it: opened personal account in 2014, on-and-off ever since — currently learning Chinese, Vietnamese, and Spanish.

Gut check: strong — Duolingo is a public company (NASDAQ: DUOL) with quarterly earnings calls, extensive press coverage, large social media presence, and a massive, vocal user base to draw from all term.



ACCOUNT SINCE 2014

app for the long run - friends who are avid users have **500+** day streaks



CHINESE COURSE

current focus language



58M+ USERS

daily actives, Q2 2026

PART 1B

Five companies are fighting for the same learner

	POSITIONING	CUSTOMER THEY WIN	WEAKNESSES
Babbel est. '07	Structured, conversation-focused curriculum for efficiency-minded adults	Working pros 25+ who'll pay for expert-made structure	No free tier; purely B2C
Rosetta Stone est. '92	Immersion method; sells directly into schools via an Education division	Institutions — 12,000+ schools, gov't & corporate contracts	Low engagement; no Gen Z audience
Preply est. '12	Marketplace connecting learners to live human tutors, incl. B2B	Career learners needing job-specific practice, e.g., business English	Expensive per session; no habit design
Busuu est. '08	Freemium app bundled into Chegg's academic ecosystem	Casual learners wanting peer feedback, low commitment	Smaller brand; not classroom-native

PART 1B

Duolingo already built the fix: Video Call proves conversation practice works. It's just locked behind Max — 9% of subscribers, not where users actually quit.

PREPLY WINS

the graduates

learners who hit the wall, then pay per lesson

DUOLINGO COULD KEEP THEM

for free

if practice moved into the free app

THE FIX

try, then buy

trade some ads for a taste of Video Call

PART 1B

Retention breaks exactly where confidence should begin

9%

of subscribers get Video Call

Duolingo's own research shows it builds real speaking confidence — but it's Max-only

12%

Day-30 retention

the exact point where "I can't really talk" turns into "I quit"

The gap

Practical basics, day one

free lessons still open with animal-and-food vocab, not greeting a friend or family member

PART 1C

Duolingo's market splits by motivation, not geography

Heritage & Identity

Who: Reconnecting with family language or culture

Wants: Emotional connection, not just fluency

Why Duolingo: vs. a paid tutor — free practice built around real greetings, not animal facts, actually serves why heritage became the #1 reason new U.S. learners started in 2021

Academic & Career

Who: School or work requires proficiency

Wants: Efficient, credentialed progress

Why Duolingo: vs. Coursera or Babbel — free daily habit-building beats paid, credential-only platforms for the 49% of English learners motivated by work or school

Casual Hobbyist

Who: Self-directed, travel or brain-training

Wants: Low-pressure, flexible practice

Why Duolingo: vs. a Preply tutor — free and gamified fits learners who cite fun over function, even pre-COVID, with no scheduling pressure

PART 1C

Gen Z is the right instinct

SUPPORTS IT

- ✓ Largest Duolingo age group is 18–24, core Gen Z
- ✓ 17–25 cohort time-spent hit an 18-month high in July
- ✓ Gen Z heritage learners spend the most time studying of any group measured

COMPLICATES IT

- ✗ Millennials are actually the larger U.S. generation (21.8% vs. 20.9%)
- ✗ 12% D30 retention is a company-wide problem, not Gen-Z-specific
- ✗ “Gen Z” is a demographic, not a needs-based segment on its own

OUR PICK

Gen Z heritage & identity learners

Young people using Duolingo to reconnect with family or cultural identity — not just because school requires it.

15%

of U.S. adults have taken a mail-in DNA test (Pew)

70%

of pandemic-era new learners cite family heritage

10.9M

followers of Xiaomanyc, the polyglot-surprise creator

APPENDIX

Sources

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